TRIANGLE

What Is Triangle?

Triangle is a design systems consultancy founded by Mike Aparicio — a principal design systems engineer with 15+ years of experience building systems at Groupon (9 years), Provi, and Turquoise Health. The name references Phil Jackson's triangle offense: a system so well-designed it outperforms reliance on any single superstar.

Website: runtriangle.com

"Run Triangle" works simultaneously as a basketball offense, a command-line instruction, and a call to action.

The Core Idea

Most CSS problems are trust problems. Teams develop methodologies — BEM, Tailwind, CSS-in-JS — not because CSS is broken, but because trust is broken. Engineers don't trust the cascade. Designers don't trust engineers to honor their designs. Teams don't trust that the system will survive when their best CSS person leaves.

Triangle's methodology — called **Playbook** — restores that trust instead of routing around it. It's a system built on roles, movement, and shared language rather than rigid rules that depend on any one person.

"The system outlasts the stars."

The pitch to clients: **you're buying the hump without the tail.** A large upfront investment that pays dividends for years, without the long-term cost of a principal engineer on staff indefinitely.

Origin Story

Mike started building websites in 1995 with a Chicago Bulls fan page. He learned CSS from designers — Jeffrey Zeldman, Dan Cederholm — not from computer science. When he joined Groupon, he was surrounded by engineers applying CS thinking to what is fundamentally a design language, and built an internal tools CSS framework that worked so well it spread organically to the consumer site and then the Merchant platform. Nobody mandated it. Teams asked for it because they saw the results.

That's the proof of concept: a system that scales without its creator having to be everywhere.

Positioning

Category: Design systems consulting

Audience: CTOs, engineering managers, heads of product at companies where designs never quite look like the picture and CSS knowledge walks out the door when people do

Tone: Confident, credible, slightly irreverent — someone who has earned their opinions and isn't afraid to say CSS education, hiring, and handoff are all broken

Key differentiator: Triangle doesn't create dependency. Most consultants leave behind something only they understand. Triangle leaves behind a system the whole team can run — including people who aren't CSS experts.

One-liner: You're buying organizational resilience. The system outlasts the stars.

Brand Personality

Authoritative without being stiff. Practitioner voice, not conference-talk voice.

Clever but not try-hard. The basketball metaphor should feel earned.

Strategic. This is systems thinking, not "we make things pretty."

A little irreverent. "The LA Clippers of websites" is a real line from the methodology writing. That energy belongs in the brand.

The Name & Metaphor

Phil Jackson's triangle offense didn't win because of Michael Jordan. It won because the system elevated the role players around him. John Paxson hit a title-winning shot. Steve Kerr hit a title-winning shot. The year Jordan retired, the Bulls won 55 games without him.

That's the analogy. Your best CSS person is going to leave someday. The question is whether your design system leaves with them.

The name also works geometrically — a triangle is foundational, stable, the basic structural unit. And there are lots of natural "threes" in the methodology itself.

Sub-Brand: Playbook

Triangle's design system methodology is called **Playbook**. It's a product/sub-brand that lives under the Triangle umbrella and will eventually need its own identity.

The name extends the basketball metaphor naturally — a playbook is the system the whole team runs from. It also crosses into mainstream business language, reinforcing that this isn't a sports gimmick.

Playbook should share DNA with Triangle (color, type, structural language) while having its own distinct feel — a family resemblance, not a copy. Full Playbook deliverables aren't needed right now, but the Triangle identity should leave room for it.

Visual Direction

Tone

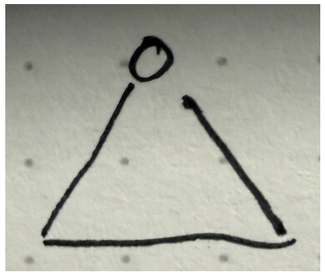
Confident and playful. The basketball reference operates in layers — subtle at first glance, more explicit as you dig in. The mark and wordmark shouldn't scream basketball, but the deeper you go into the brand (copy, methodology, swag), the more the thread reveals itself. Think of it as a reward for paying attention.

Color

- **Primary:** Blue inspired by the Chicago flag (#009bde or similar) — the founder is from Chicago, and the Bulls connection is part of the brand's DNA. The Chicago flag blue may need a slight deepening to achieve sufficient contrast on white backgrounds; the designer should find the closest viable version rather than abandoning the reference.
- **Accent:** Orange — the blue/orange pairing is a direct nod to basketball without being tied to any specific team.

Visual Direction

The Mark



A **broken triangle with a small circle at the apex.** The broken line is intentional — they represent ball movement, not an incomplete shape. The circle represents the ball. Together they suggest a player or formation at the top of the offense. (This is one idea, but I'm open to others.)

This mark needs to:

- Work as a standalone symbol (favicon, avatar, sticker, embroidery)
- Hold up at small sizes
- Reproduce cleanly in single-color
- Be bold and simple enough to work on a hat, a jersey, or a sticker — sports logo rules apply

Wordmark

"Triangle" as a typographic treatment, separate from but compatible with the mark. Both should work independently and together as a lockup.

Deliverables Needed

- **Mark** — the standalone icon; works as favicon, avatar, sticker
- **Wordmark** — "Triangle" as a typographic treatment
- **Lockup** — mark + wordmark together, with clear rules for when to use each separately
- **Color palette** — primary blue, accent orange, plus neutrals; with monochrome variants
- **Typography pairing**
- **Basic brand guidelines** — usage rules for web, presentations, and swag

Swag Considerations

The mark especially needs to hold up at small sizes, work on dark and light backgrounds, and reproduce cleanly in single-color (screen printing, embroidery). Stickers are a priority use case.

Context

Triangle's first major deliverable is a consulting website (runtriangle.com). The brand needs to work especially well on the web. The founder also maintains a personal site (MikeAparicio.com) — its current design should not influence Triangle's direction, but it's a useful reference for the founder's personal voice and tone.

Reference Points

These are things the founder has been looking at and thinking about — not a direction to copy, just inspiration to help establish a starting point. Something completely different that makes sense is equally welcome.

- **Arc Raiders** (video game) — the in-game organization logos and UI have an aesthetic that resonates: geometric, pseudo-futuristic. See: arcraiders.wiki/wiki/Category:Organization_Logos
- The craft credibility of Brad Frost's or Dan Mall's personal sites (voice and positioning, not visual direction)
- Serif font for body copy. Something with some style that’s not found on every other website. (Slide font is Jovie VF, for example.)